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Enjoying Movies On Your PC

Agent goes around the market place foraging for his new HTPC

After the hectic schedule last month, most of us were relaxing late one evening in our office and dreaming on how to splurge with the extra moolah from our annual increment. While one had planned a week off to Goa, another planned a long drive to visit family in Bangalore. I'd been hankering after an HTPC and with some extra money at hand, this finally seemed to be closer to reality. I managed to rope in another test centre buddy who was interested in something similar.

You can build / assemble a superb HTPC on your own, without any hassles. An HTPC is just like any other ordinary PC—multipurpose, except that it is aimed at realising a more realistic movie experience over a desktop. There are no special components that make up an HTPC—all you need is a reasonably fast processor with at least 1 GB RAM, an entry level graphics card or even a good onboard solution, a large widescreen monitor or TV (22 inch-

es being a decent start) and a reasonable set of surround speakers (preferably 5.1). This relatively high configuration allows you to enjoy HD videos, which are encoded at resolutions of 1280x720 (720p) and 1080p (1920x1080) with progressive scanning. With Blu-ray media slated to become common by 2009, this investment could very well be rewarding in the long run. Similarly, rich multimedia content weighs heavily on system resources, though the presence of a GPU does alleviate the stress.

Look for a good LCD panel—a 22-inch TN will suffice—although something in the range of 24 inches would be better. If you can afford premium panels such as MVA and PVA, that would be the icing on the cake. Also, if you have a large LCD or Plasma TV, you could use the same. If any of you happen to have a decent gaming PC, or even a powerful multimedia PC with a good monitor, then you already have the essentials for a good HTPC. The only other aspect is the noise levels—

HTPCs should be silent. Choose the cabinet and power supply carefully (if you are building from scratch). While efficient cooling is must, excessive noise is a strict no-no.

With the many options available to both of us, we had a tough time deciding what to buy. We visited Lamington Road, here in Mumbai a couple of times during the weekend. All the vendors we visited suggested the Intel platform. According to them, an integrated graphics processor (IGP) is the way to go. For an Intel-based PC, the G35 chipset makes a lot of sense. Based on the GMA x3500 GPU core, the G35 incorporates DirectX 10 graphics, HDMI support and digital audio outputs. The G33 is based around the less powerful x3100 GPU (2 less shader units than the G35). The 780G chipset (AMD-only platform) from ATI is a stronger contender for an HTPC, especially, if you're not buying a discrete graphics card. The 780G adds a powerful DX10-ready GPU in the form of the Radeon HD3200.

NVIDIA's latest GeForce 8200 series of chipsets offer support for both platforms (Intel and AMD), and offers similar features such as H.264 and AVC hardware decoding, not found in the G35/G33m, significantly freeing up your CPU. This also enables seamless Blu-ray playback. The only issue is this chipset's (GeForce 8200) lack of availability in our markets at the time of writing this. Besides, the vendors we asked couldn't give us any concrete quotes or time frames. My colleague wanted an Intel solution, while I remained fixated on an AMD-based HTPC configuration.

After looking at four or five options, I decided on Gigabyte's GA-MA78GM-S2H (AMD 780G). It's well built, feature-rich, (Optical outs, HDMI, 2 PCI slots, 5 SATA ports), and has solid-state capacitors for durability. For the processor, after pouring over some features and specifications, I went for AMD's spanking new 65-nm "green" CPUs. At 2.1 GHz, the BE-2350 processor gives me all the horsepower I needed for any kind of HD or Blu-ray content, with power consumption of a mere 45 watts. I managed to get a combined price for the CPU and motherboard. I decided on a little extra memory and invested in 2 GB of DDR2 800 MHz memory from Transcend (integrated solutions utilise system memory, remember?). I already had a 250 GB hard drive, my 24-inch monitor and 5.1 speakers (Logitech). So, my only remaining purchases included a

compact cabinet and matching power supply. I came across two cabinets that caught my attention—Antec's NSK1300 (with a cube-like form factor) and CoolerMaster's CM Media 260. The former is a very compact cube-like cabinet, and is very well-built. The CM 260 is a little higher, but a lot slimmer, and can fit an ATX-sized motherboard (the NSK1300 can manage Micro-ATX only). This cabinet also comes with a media centre unit (remote and receiver with necessary software).

My colleague wanted to connect his HTPC to his LCD TV directly, and was shopping for an HDMI-to-DVI converter. While I argued that his motherboard already had an HDMI port and that he was wasting his time searching for a graphics card, he argued that he wanted to game a bit as well. For a motherboard, we finally picked up a Gigabyte GA-G33M-S2H (G33). ASUS' P5E-VM HDMI (G35-based Intel solution), looked good, but at Rs 9,500 (board only) was too expensive. For the processor, he was looking at something basic, and was torn between an E2180 (Pentium Dual Core) and an E4300 (Core 2 Duo). Since he was going for a graphics card, I recommended the cheaper CPU—the E2180. I suggest a GeForce 8400GS for the video card. I wanted a fan-less solution (for less noise). The ASUS GeForce 8400GS Silent was our pick at Rs 3,200. He'd already bought a mini ATX form factor cabinet and 400-watt power supply from VIP

earlier, so his build was complete, since he had 5.1 speakers.

We couldn't find branded stuff in Lamington Road, and eventually ended up buying a regular unbranded six feet long HDMI-to-DVI cable for Rs 1,900. HDMI cables were even cheaper—Rs 900. Although many people swear by costly brands, I feel that the difference (if any) is minimal, and definitely not worth the premium you pay for upmarket stuff.

We also tried looking for Media Centre remote and receiver kits that work with Windows XP MCE and Vista. Unfortunately, we came across many Chinese remote units with no receivers! It seems most people looking for a media centre PC remote unit usually end up buying a wireless keyboard and mouse kit...and with the paltry options available to us, I can't blame them. I guess I was lucky to get such an option along with my cabinet.

Although the HTPCs we built weren't exactly cheap, a much cheaper PC could be built by saving on costly LCD panels, expensive speakers etc. The fact that we already had half the components with us was the reason we stayed with them, else a decent 22-inch monitor would cost no more than 13,000 bucks. That's the beauty of an HTPC—spend more, get more! I've banged out this write-up on the same PC, and while I watch a quick movie, I leave you to pore over the detailed specifications below. ■

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HTPC BUILDS	BUILD 1		BUILD 2	
	Components	Price	Components	Price
Processor	AMD Athlon BE-2350	Rs 8,300 (combo offer)	Intel Pentium Dual Core E2180	Rs 3,250
Motherboard	Gigabyte GA-MA78GM-S2H		Gigabyte GA-G33M-S2H	Rs 6,100
RAM	Transcend 2x1 GB DDR2 667	Rs 2,000	Kingston 1 GB DDR2 667	Rs 950
Discrete Graphics solution (if any)	NA	NA	ASUS GeForce 8400GS Silent	Rs 3,200
Hard Drive	Seagate 7200.10 250 GB	Rs 2,100	Western Digital WD3200KS	Rs 3,000
Monitor / Display	Dell E248WFP	Rs 18,500	Samsung 32-inch Bordeaux LA32 R81	Rs 42,000
Cabinet / Power Supply	CM Media 260 + Antec 350W	Rs 8,500	VIP Micro ATX case / 400 W PSU	Rs 4,200
Keyboard / Mouse / remote	Logitech wireless desktop basic	Rs 1,800	Logitech wireless desktop basic	Rs 1,800
Speakers	Logitech Z5300E	Rs 11,000	Altec Lansing VS3251	Rs 3,700
Total		Rs 52,200		Rs 68,200